Rahul Gandhi’s Imprint

One striking reaction that came from all the groups who met Rahul Gandhi was how much and how carefully he listened. He asked follow-up questions and, where necessary, quickly sought to find a way to provide relief. Where people were making suggestions, he did try to take it beyond an exploratory conversation, towards policy recommendations that could be tangibly implemented as a result of these conversations. Where the idea or suggestion drew support and endorsement, he sought to help make these policies a reality. For instance, in states such as Rajasthan he explored ways in which the state government could consider formulating and implementing the policy. This is how the gig workers’ legislation made rapid progress in Rajasthan. One group met him per day. The number was small enough for everyone to get a chance to talk to him properly and explain what they had come to say. He listened. He asked a series of questions. Many came with specific grievances and papers, and in Rajasthan he sought help from everyone he could reach out to, including the chief minister, and redress grievances small and big.

On petitions and suggestions that involved policy initiatives, he spent time understanding the issue and requesting senior party leaders on the Yatra to help with follow-ups. Often, when moved by someone’s plight, he would have a short phone call with the chief minister requesting his immediate intervention and support. This is the image of accessible political leadership that is sorely needed in India. Walking along, he reached out to talk to someone from the crowd waiting to wave to him or walking at the back. He had the freedom to do so as he was not constrained by security, or the pomp and exclusiveness of being privileged. He played with children, connected to their pets. He slowed his brisk pace when he was walking with an elderly person. He showed grit and determination to be ordinary, doing what they do—and in that being truly extraordinary.

In Rajasthan, he decided that as the eighteen days in the state would draw to a close, there would be one meeting with all the civil society groups in attendance together. These groups would first meet the state leadership of